


**NOT IN OUR NAME** Bhopal denizens protesting the presence of traders in residential areas

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

# Bhopal, Now a Concrete Tragedy

**A realty-friendly new draft Master Plan makes it legal, proposing easy amnesty for controversial violations**

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**IT LOOKS IDEAL—VISION AND OVERSIGHT ALL AT ONCE.** On September 26, Madhya Pradesh unveiled a draft Bhopal Development Plan 2047. It's a guiding document for what would be allowed or not allowed by way of construction and activity—a sore necessity since the city hasn't updated its Master Plan since 1995. What's more, the Supreme Court is keeping watch. The state's draft-making was lent a decisive turn by an ongoing case, *Loganathan vs State of Tamil Nadu*, where the court critiqued commercial use of residential areas across India. Nowhere perhaps had that wreaked havoc on civic life as in dainty Bhopal. So, order was returning.

Or was it? Read the prologue again. The Master Plan presently in place, conceived in an altogether different era, ran out its 10-year course in 2005. Why could successive governments not draft a new one for 21 years? Ascribe it to the builder-politician-bureaucrat triumvirate—all players with high stakes. Judge only by the fact that two attempts in the past 18 years to approve a new Master Plan were shelved owing to pressure. That base equation hasn't changed. So, while the state has given an undertaking that it will not implement the plan without the SC's approval, its draft provisions do not seem quite in sync with the ruling.

One key proposal is to link permissible activities in a building to the width of the road where it is located—doing away with the principle of exclusive commercial and residential areas altogether. Three categories of roads have been identified: 12 m, 18 m and 24 m width, with permissible activities in each listed. The concept of Transit Oriented Development (TOD) comes in for a 500-m zone on either side of the Metro. Transferable Development Rights (TDR), too, make its Bhopal debut—an owner who surrenders land getting compensated in kind. In short, realty is the new reality.

But citizens living in the zone identified as RG 3, one of the largest areas to be affected by decades of scammy commercial use of residential property, have been left aghast. Land use in RG 3, which includes Arera Colony, Char Imli, Gandhi Nagar, Chunabhatti and Shamla Hills, has been nominally marked as 'residential'. The road width criterion does not extend to it. Instead, the draft has introduced a provision for legalising the illegal structures that choke it. For those who run it, overwhelmingly the politico-professional elite of the city,

**Takeaways**

- **Draft Master Plan abandons residential-commercial split**
- **'Road width' criterion to decide if a shop is legal**
- **Spurred by SC flak, Plan legalises what was illegal**